

THE CLAIM

A rival is turning three of your private equity partners into the market's middle-market PE brand. Your hiring since October is roughly even, so the ground you are losing is not the bench. It is the story the next rainmaker and the next fund read before they choose.

The story that names the market's mid-market PE leader is what pulls the next portable book, and what tilts a fund's read when both firms chase one mandate. The rival is marketing that story, on a platform it built partly from your departed partners, after every hire. Below is what I read from it, and the call I will be graded on.

THE EVIDENCE

- 01 **A chain, not scattered churn.** A senior partner left the client's PE group for the rival in October 2025. Four months later two more from his group followed him, joining, in the rival's own announcement, on the heels of the first. One partner first, then two of his group behind him. That is the signature of a targeted pull, not random attrition.
- 02 **The single largest feeder of a multi-firm build.** The rival also took PE partners from two elite national firms and a third large firm in the same window. Ten partners joined it in 2026, and it was the No. 1 Am Law 200 firm for lateral hires in its state in 2025. Across that build, the client supplied more of the rival's PE partners than any other single firm, and the only connected group.